Speech at Wheeling, West Virginia

Sen. Joseph R. McCarthy (R-WI) · February 9, 1950 · widely-reprinted version

Source: Joseph R. McCarthy, speech at Wheeling, West Virginia (Feb. 9, 1950), prepared text entered in the Congressional Record, via Teaching American History (its editorial cuts are shown as . . .). Public domain.

Joseph McCarthy was a then-obscure first-term senator when he addressed a Republican women's club in Wheeling. He held up a paper he claimed listed 205 Communists working in the State Department. The exact number shifted over the next several speeches — 205, 57, 81 — and the original text was never preserved verbatim. The Wheeling speech launched four years of McCarthy hearings, Senate investigations, and the broader Red Scare known as 'McCarthyism.'

Connect: The Second Red Scare produced blacklists, loyalty oaths, and reputation destruction. Compare the atmosphere of 1950-54 to the Alien and Sedition Acts era (Class 7). What repeats?

Key Passages

The framing of the global struggle

Today we are engaged in a final, all-out battle between communistic atheism and Christianity. The modern champions of communism have selected this as the time, and ladies and gentlemen, the chips are down – they are truly down.

The enemy within

The reason why we find ourselves in a position of impotency is not because our only powerful potential enemy has sent men to invade our shores – but rather because of the traitorous actions of those who have been treated so well by this Nation. … This is glaringly true in the State Department. There the bright young men who are born with silver spoons in their mouths are the ones who have been most traitorous.

The claim

I have here in my hand a list of 205 – a list of names that were made known to the Secretary of State as being members of the Communist Party and who nevertheless are still working and shaping policy in the State Department.

HIPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	The Second Red Scare: the Soviet atomic bomb, the fall of China to communism (1949), the Alger Hiss case, and rising fear of communist spies in government.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	A Republican women's club in Wheeling, and through the press, the American public and the Truman administration.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	Joseph McCarthy, an ambitious Republican senator who used anticommunism for political gain; those he accused had no chance to respond.
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. DBQ Sourcing — HIPP for 3 McCarthyism docs (1 pt): Write one sentence each on Historical situation, Intended audience, Purpose, and POV for this speech.
2. Why was a senator like McCarthy able to make sensational claims with no evidence and gain national traction?
3. What ended McCarthy's power — and when?

Speech at Wheeling, West Virginia

Senator Joseph R. McCarthy · February 9, 1950

Source: Joseph R. McCarthy, speech at Wheeling, West Virginia (Feb. 9, 1950), prepared text entered in the Congressional Record, via Teaching American History (its editorial cuts are shown as . . .). Public domain. Non-contiguous passages are separated by [. . .]; shorter cuts inside a passage are marked with an ellipsis (. . .).

> McCarthy's claim to hold a list of Communists in the State Department launched the anticommunist "Red Scare" of the 1950s. No complete transcript survives; this is the text McCarthy later placed in the record. (He said "57" here; newspapers reported "205.")

The framing of the global struggle

Five years after a world war has been won, men's hearts should anticipate a long peace – and men's minds should be free from the heavy weight that comes with war. But this is not such a period – for this is not a period of peace. This is a time of the cold war. This is a time when all the world is split into two vast, increasingly hostile, armed camps – a time of a great armament race.

[. . .]

The one encouraging thing is that the mad moment has not yet arrived for the firing of the gun or the exploding of the bomb which will set civilization about the final task of destroying itself. There is still a hope for peace if we finally decide that no longer can we safely blind our eyes and close our ears to those facts which are shaping up more and more clearly – and that is that we are now engaged in a show-down fight – not the usual war between nations for land areas or other material gains, but a war between two diametrically opposed ideologies.

The great difference between our western Christian world and the atheistic Communist world is not political, gentlemen, it is moral. . . . The real, basic difference, however, lies in the religion of immoralism – invented by Marx, preached feverishly by Lenin, and carried to unimaginable extremes by Stalin. This religion of immoralism, if the Red half of the world triumphs – and well it may, gentlemen – this religion of immoralism will more deeply wound and damage mankind than any conceivable economic or political system.

[. . .]

Today we are engaged in a final, all-out battle between communistic atheism and Christianity. The modern champions of communism have selected this as the time, and ladies and gentlemen, the chips are down – they are truly down.

[. . .]

Ladies and gentlemen, can there be anyone tonight who is so blind as to say that the war is not on? Can there be anyone who fails to realize that the Communist world has said the time is now – that this is the time for the show-down between the democratic Christian world and the communistic atheistic world? Unless we face this fact, we shall pay the price that must be paid by those who wait too long.

The enemy within

Six years ago . . . there was within the Soviet orbit, 180,000,000 people. Lined up on the anti-totalitarian side there were in the world at that time, roughly 1,625,000,000 people. Today, only six years later, there are 80,000,000,000 people under the absolute domination of Soviet Russia – an increase of over 400 percent. On our side, the figure has shrunk to around 500,000. In other words, in less than six years, the odds have changed from 9 to 1 in our favor to 8 to 1 against us.

This indicates the swiftness of the tempo of Communist victories and American defeats in the cold war. As one of our outstanding historical figures once said, “When a great democracy is destroyed, it will not be from enemies from without, but rather because of enemies from within”

[. . .]

The reason why we find ourselves in a position of impotency is not because our only powerful potential enemy has sent men to invade our shores – but rather because of the traitorous actions of those who have been treated so well by this Nation. It has not been the less fortunate, or members of minority groups who have been traitorous to this Nation – but rather those who have had all the benefits that the wealthiest Nation on earth has had to offer – the finest homes, the finest college education and the finest jobs in government we can give. This is glaringly true in the State Department. There the bright young men who are born with silver spoons in their mouths are the ones who have been most traitorous.

[. . .]

The claim

I have here in my hand a list of 205 – a list of names that were made known to the Secretary of State as being members of the Communist Party and who nevertheless are still working and shaping policy in the State Department.

Words to know

diametrically opposed — completely and directly opposite
atheistic — denying the existence of God
immoralism — a belief system that rejects all moral rules
Soviet orbit — the countries under Soviet control or influence
impotency — powerlessness; inability to act
traitorous — betraying one’s own country